FLORIDA GULF COAST GUIDE

October, 2026

IN THIS ISSUE



Welcome to the October 2026 edition. In this issue, we highlight Spencer Glen in Riverview, a new 743-acre development in North Port, and local farmers markets.





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MARKET UPDATE

Prices up in three counties, down in Hillsborough.

COMMUNITY FOCUS

Spencer Glen, another community by Pulte Homes in the same style as Vida's Way and Riversong, brings Pulte's quality build closer to Tampa.

IN DEVELOPMENT

I-75 at Fruitville, a Rays ballpark plan and a 743-acre Wellen Park expansion vote.

SOCIAL MINUTE

Three farmers markets worth keeping on your weekend radar.

IT'S 5 O'CLOCK SOMEWHERE!

Taking a look at Florence and the Spice Boys, one of the best happy hours in Lakewood Ranch.

DOLLARS & CENTS

Rates, buy downs and builder incentives: what to ask before you fall in love with the payment.

COST OF LIVING & MOVING

Moving costs, vehicle fees, taxes and our estimators.

MARKET UPDATE

September showed a split market. Single-family prices rose in Sarasota (+7.8%), Pinellas (+9.4%) and Manatee (+3.2%) and dipped slightly in Hillsborough (−1.3%). Sales fell year over year everywhere except Sarasota, and homes went under contract faster than a year ago in three of the four counties.

THE RUNDOWN

Sept. 2026 single-family medians: Sarasota $485,000 · Manatee $485,000 · Pinellas $465,000 · Hillsborough $419,450.

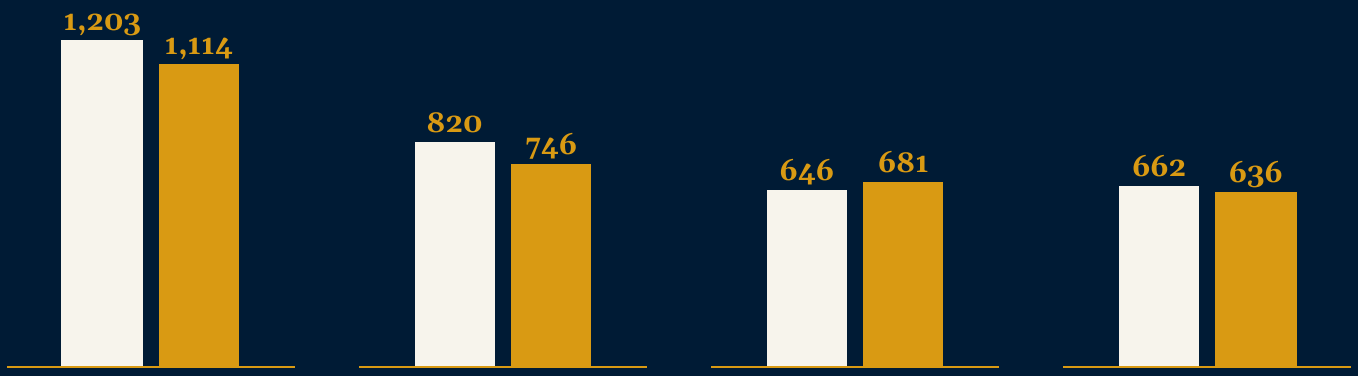
NOTE TO BUYERS

Condos have 5 to 6.5 months of supply, which gives buyers more room to negotiate. Single-family supply is 3.7 to 4.0 months.

NOTE TO SELLERS

Pricing from peak-season emotion is risky. Presentation and realistic strategy matter.

SINGLE-FAMILY CLOSED SALES — SEPTEMBER



Median $419,450 (−1.3%)
40 days to contract

Median $465,000 (+9.4%)
36 days to contract

Median $485,000 (+7.8%)
51 days to contract

Median $485,000 (+3.2%)
53 days to contract

IN DEVELOPMENT

A HIGHWAY, A BALLPARK AND WELLEN PARK

I-75 AT FRUITVILLE ROAD

FDOT is rebuilding Exit 210 as a diverging diamond and widening about 2 miles of I-75 to six lanes ($177.4M). Completion is expected in 2029. Plan around overnight lane and ramp closures.

RAYS BALLPARK DISTRICT

The Tampa Bay Rays plan a new fixed-roof ballpark, opening in 2029, as the centerpiece of a mixed-use district at Hillsborough College's Dale Mabry campus, across from Raymond James Stadium. Hillsborough County approved the funding agreement Aug. 28, 2026, and Tampa City Council took a further financing step on Oct. 15. More approvals are still ahead. The Rays play at Tropicana Field in St. Petersburg through 2028.



WELLEN PARK · THE 743-ACRE VOTE

On Oct 20, 2026, North Port's City Commission approved the Wellen Park Village HL master concept plan, with conditions, on about 743 acres south of US-41 and east of South River Road, near the Myakka River. It allows up to 1,875 homes plus 400,000 sq ft of retail and services and 100,000 sq ft of professional and medical office space. The vote was 4-1; the dissenting commissioner raised environmental concerns. What it means: Wellen Park's North Port side is set to keep growing, with more homes, shops and offices planned.

SOCIAL MINUTE

MANATEE AND SARASOTA FARMERS MARKETS

A QUICK GULF COAST RESET

Farmers markets are one of the easiest ways to understand a place. You see small businesses, local products, seasonal produce and the everyday rhythm of a community.

As the region has grown, so have the options for weekend markets, independent businesses and community events.

Pick one, go early and let the morning tell you something about the area.





SARASOTA FARMERS MARKET

Downtown Sarasota

A year-round city classic with produce, flowers, food vendors and strong “Saturday morning downtown” energy.

Best for: browsing, coffee and walkability.

BRADENTON PUBLIC MARKET

Old Main Street, Bradenton

A friendly downtown Manatee County market with local vendors and a strong community feel.

Best for: local flavor.

FARMERS MARKET AT LAKEWOOD RANCH

Waterside Place

A polished, lively market with lakefront energy, prepared foods, vendors and nearby shops.

Best for: new to the area weekends.

DOLLARS & CENTS

As of Oct 22, 2026, the national 30-year fixed average is 7.32%, up from 6.52% in June. On a $500,000 loan that is about $268 a month more in principal and interest. The headline rate is only one part of the deal: APR, points, loan type and adjustment risk also matter.

RATES WE SEE

Freddie Mac, Oct 22, 2026: 30-year fixed 7.32%, 15-year 6.68%. Principal and interest at 7.32%: $3,435 a month on $500,000; $2,748 on $400,000. Builders, including Pulte at Spencer Glen, advertise below-market and ARM financing; ask for the rate in writing, what it costs and how an ARM adjusts.

SELLING STRATEGY

Private sellers may face challenges competing with builders as they are better prepared and financially designed to handle various market conditions. Sellers need to use all the tools available to attract a wider audience of buyers. Consider offering closing cost assistance, rates buy downs and accommodating terms.

BUYING STRATEGY

Compare price, loan type, APR, points, closing costs, mortgage insurance, future adjustment risk, HOA/CDD fees and resale fit, not just the monthly teaser.

LOCAL MARKET · SEPT. 2026

Single-family medians (year over year): Sarasota $485,000 (+7.8%), Manatee $485,000 (+3.2%), Pinellas $465,000 (+9.4%), Hillsborough $419,450 (**−1.3%**). Condo/townhome medians: Sarasota $335,000 (+6.3%), Manatee $296,500 (0.0%), Hillsborough $255,650 (**−8.7%**), Pinellas $246,750 (+3.7%). Trends differ by county and property type.

TAXES & FEES

Homestead: file with your county property appraiser by March 1st. Save Our Homes caps later increases at 3% or CPI, whichever is lower (2.7% for 2026). License $48 (+ possible $6.25 fee); registering a typical car is about $361.

INCENTIVES WORTH NOTING

Preferred lender promotion · rate buy-down · closing-cost credit · flex cash or design credit · quick-move-in incentive · HOA/CDD fee concession.

EXAMPLE PAYMENTS COMPARISON

Illustrative payments, NOT MORTGAGE RATE QUOTES · $500,000 loan

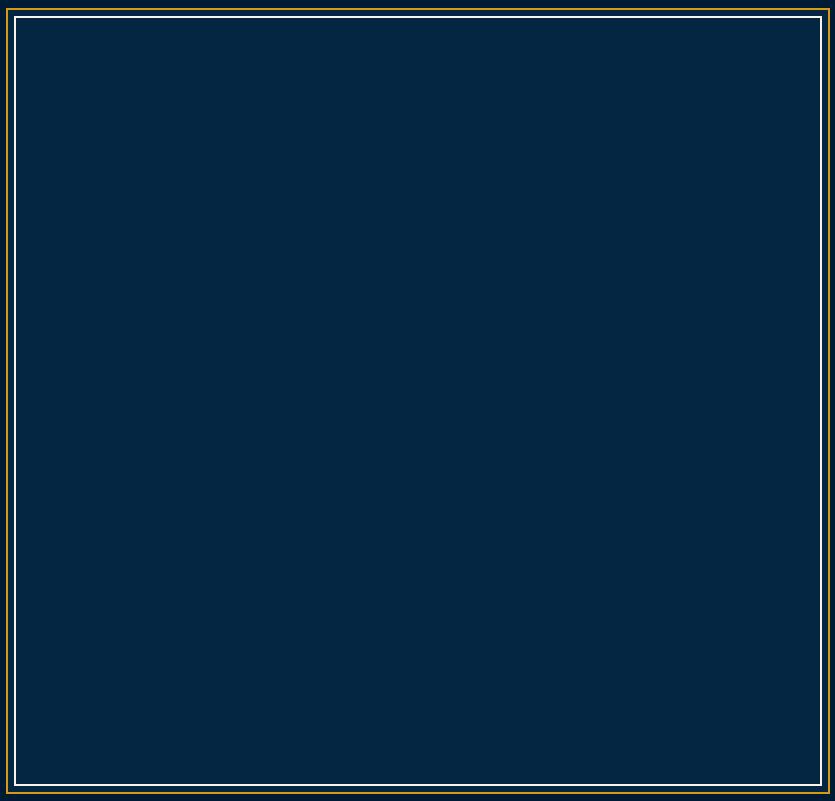


Illustrative monthly principal-and-interest payments. Examples exclude property taxes, homeowners insurance, mortgage insurance, flood insurance and HOA/CDD assessments.

IT'S 5 O'CLOCK SOMEWHERE!

FLORENCE & THE SPICE BOYS

A food truck that started in 2019 now serves modern Middle Eastern street food at UTC, and its happy hour is one of the better deals in town.



Florence & The Spice Boys began as a food truck in 2019. Today the UTC location, in the West District, serves modern Middle Eastern street food with an indoor-outdoor bar.

Must-try: the chicken shawarma dish. The turmeric fried chicken sandwich and the falafel pita taco are close behind, and Florence's desserts, like the Goldfish sugar cookie, are worth saving room for.

Happy hour is the easy way in: daily from 3 to 5. Stay from 5 to 6, order off the regular menu, and martinis are 99 cents.

THE DETAILS

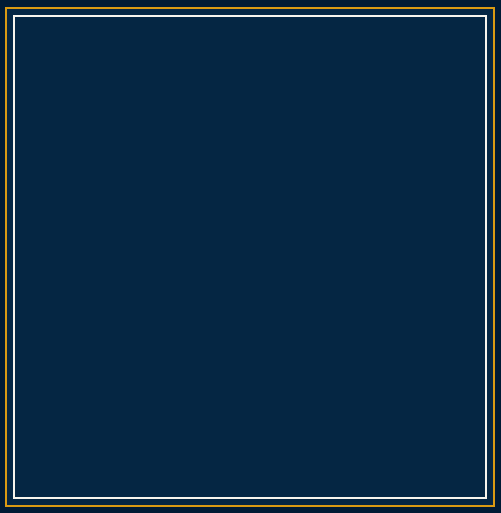
UTC · West District
257 N Cattlemen Rd, Unit 90
Sarasota, FL 34243
(941) 359-8338

HAPPY HOUR

Daily 3-5 pm
$6 margarita · $7 martini of the day
$5 draft, prosecco and wine
$5 masabacha hummus, chicken pita, falafel pita, tempura cauliflower
Bonus 5-6 pm: $0.99 martini with a regular menu item

HOURS

Dining: Sun-Thu 11 am-9 pm; Fri-Sat 11 am-10 pm
Bar: Sun-Thu to 10 pm; Fri-Sat to midnight



COMMUNITY FOCUS

SPENCER GLEN AT RIVERVIEW



SPENCER GLEN · THE BUZZ

A new Pulte Homes community in southern Riverview, about a mile from the I-75/Big Bend Road interchange and US-301, with single-family and multigenerational "AllGen" plans and a resort-style amenity center at its heart.





SPENCER GLEN · HIGHLIGHTS

Homes of 1,662 to 4,272 sq ft. AllGen plans add a private suite with living area, bedroom, bath and optional kitchenette. Builder base prices from $400,990 (Oct 22, 2026; changes often, excludes lot premiums and options; not a sale price). Models at 13716 Sunlight Meadow Dr.

SPENCER GLEN · AMENITIES

Clubhouse · zero-entry resort-style pool with private cabanas · fitness center and screened game room · pickleball · playground and dog park · walking trails.

WHAT MAKES SPENCER GLEN DIFFERENT

Southern Riverview, nestled next to I-75 with quick access to Tampa and beyond: about 20 miles to downtown Tampa and 45 miles to Sarasota. HOA about $91/month and CDD about $2,194-$2,921/year.

COST OF LIVING & MOVING

THE MOVE ITSELF

HireAHelper's average for a long-distance (about 1,200 mi) 4-bedroom move: about **$7,393** with full-service movers, or about **$2,719** with a DIY truck.

VEHICLE FEES

$225 initial registration per vehicle new to Florida, plus title ($85.25, used vehicle), plate ($28), base vehicle tax and other statutory fees.

INSURANCE

County averages for homeowners premiums, including wind, are on Insurance & Storms, p. 11. Get a quote for the specific house before you write an offer.

FEES & TAXES

CDD fees often appear on the tax bill; HOA dues are billed separately. Property tax resets after a sale.

ESTIMATE YOUR MOVE



MOVING COST ESTIMATOR

START YOUR ESTIMATE

YOUR AREA LOCATOR

FIND YOUR AREA

COST OF LIVING ESTIMATOR

COMPARE

HAVE A SUCCESSFUL MOVE



GET AN INSURANCE QUOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE AN OFFER.

Flood zone, roof age and elevation can change your monthly payment as much as the price of the house.

LOOK PAST THE ASKING PRICE.

In new communities, ask for the CDD and HOA schedules in writing. Those fees can go up year after year.

DRIVER'S LICENSE

Get a Florida license within **30 days** of establishing residency. Class E: $48, plus a possible $6.25 office fee.

TITLE & REGISTRATION

Get Florida insurance, then title and register each car within **10 days** of establishing residency.

HOMESTEAD

File with your county property appraiser by March 1st.

YOUR TAX BILL WILL CHANGE

A sale resets assessed value on January 1. After your first homestead year, increases are capped at 3% or CPI, whichever is lower.

INSURANCE & STORMS

WEATHER, STORMS AND THE COST OF COVER



HURRICANE SEASON

NOAA's updated 2026 Atlantic hurricane outlook (Aug 6) gives a 75% chance of a below-normal season, a 20% chance of near normal and a 5% chance of above-normal activity.

THE CLIMATE

January highs are in the low 70s; June to September highs run near 91°F. About 60% of the roughly 49 inches of yearly rain falls June to September, mostly in afternoon storms. Hurricane season runs June 1 to Nov 30.

FLOOD IS SEPARATE

Standard homeowners policies don't cover flood. New flood policies usually have a 30-day wait, except at a purchase with a mortgage.

LOW RISK ISN'T NO RISK

Nearly 1 in 4 flood insurance claims are paid on policies in low-to-moderate-risk zones (X and X500), per the City of Sarasota.

INSURANCE AVERAGES

Homeowners premium incl. wind, all policies in force as of Mar 31, 2026 (not a quote): Hillsborough $3,525 · Pinellas $4,063 · Sarasota $3,457 · Manatee $3,181 a year.

PREP BASICS

Check the parcel on FEMA's flood map and ask for the wind mitigation report.

THANK YOU!



If you'd like to discuss your search further, don't hesitate to schedule a call.

BOOK A CALL

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Equal Housing Opportunity

SOURCES

ACCESSED OCTOBER 2026 · FIGURES CHANGE; VERIFY BEFORE DECIDING

Market Update (p. 3). Florida Realtors monthly county detail reports with Stellar MLS data, September 2026, released Oct 16, 2026: Hillsborough and Pinellas STAR reports (pinellasrealtor.org); Sarasota and Manatee detail PDFs (myrasm.com). Totals and charts computed from these reports.

In Development (p. 4). FDOT District One project 420613-2 (swflroads.com); Sarasota/Manatee MPO Traffic Watch, week of Oct 18, 2026; Groundbreak, Oct 16, 2026 (Rays district). Wellen Park: City of North Port Resolution 2026-R-68, passed Oct 20, 2026 (docketcity.com); North Port Legistar file PMCP-25-02757 staff report; yoursun.com, Daniel Finton, Oct 22, 2026 (vote tally); WSLR, Oct 18, 2026.

Dollars & Cents (p. 6). Freddie Mac PMMS, Oct 22, 2026 (freddiemac.com/pmms; FRED MORTGAGE30US); Mortgage News Daily, Oct 22, 2026; June figure 6.52% from the June 2026 guide; P&I computed from these rates; Florida Realtors / Stellar MLS Sept. 2026 county reports, released Oct 16, 2026 (pinellasrealtor.org Hillsborough and Pinellas STAR reports; myrasm.com Sarasota and Manatee single-family and condo detail PDFs); FL DOR homestead CPI notice and Save Our Homes page; FLHSMV fee schedule; Pulte Spencer Glen page (financing).

Social Minute. Farmers markets: Sarasota Farmers Market; Realize Bradenton; Lakewood Ranch Farmers Market. Florence & The Spice Boys: florenceandthespiceboys.com: UTC happy hour menu and UTC location page (accessed Oct 22, 2026); utcsarasota.com happy hour roundup; Your Observer, May 20, 2026; Sarasota Magazine, Apr 2025 and Feb 2023.

Community Focus (p. 8). pulte.com/homes/florida/tampa/riverview/spencer-glen-211225; Osprey Observer, Dec 2025; drive estimates from OSRM / OpenStreetMap routing (no traffic, Oct 22, 2026); fees from estatevida.com and jome.com.

Relocation chapters (pp. 9-12). Census Bureau Vintage 2025; UF Shimberg Center; FAU Florida Climate Survey via WLRN, Dec 1, 2025; FL DOR (no personal income tax; PT112, PT107); RASM Q3 2026; North River Ranch ISD adopted schedules; Lakewood Ranch Stewardship District FY2027 assessments; Florida Realtors / Stellar MLS Sept. 2026; HireAHelper 2026 tables; ConsumerMovingReviews Moving Cost Report 2026; FLHSMV fee schedule and new-resident page.

Insurance & Storms (p. 11). FL OIR July 2026 Property Insurance Stability Report, data as of Mar 31, 2026 (floir.gov/docs-sf/default-source/property-and-casualty/stability-unit-reports/july-2026-isu-report.pdf); NOAA CPC updated 2026 Atlantic Hurricane Season Outlook, issued Aug 6, 2026 (cpc.ncep.noaa.gov/products/outlooks/hurricane.shtml); NOAA NCEI 1991-2020 normals, Tampa Intl; NWS Tampa Bay normals, SRQ; NOAA NHC; City of Sarasota Emergency Preparedness Guide 2024 and Flood Information page; FEMA Flood Map Service Center.

Image credits. Truck on highway: “CSIRO ScienceImage 3497 Truck on highway rural NSW” by Carl Davies, CSIRO, via Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 3.0 (creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0), cropped. p. 10: stock image, Envato Elements (licensed). Some graphics may have been created or adjusted with the help of AI; the farmers market scenes are AI-assisted illustrations based on real photographs, and details may differ from the actual markets.

Insurance figures are averages of policies in force, not quotes. Moving costs are published averages. Payments are illustrative, not rate quotes.